Ashutosh eventually contested the Lok Sabha elections on an AAP ticket, one of quite a few journalists to take the bait. Kejriwal had, as Amit Shah had suggested at Jaitley's lunch, once offered me the lure of a ticket. 'We need good people in politics, you must join us,' he said earnestly. This was not the first time a political party had suggested that I make the switch. My response each time was much the same. 'Thank you, but no thank you. Happy to observe politics from a distance.' I loved journalism too much to lose my independence. Besides, I didn't have the thick skin that *netagiri* required and was far from endorsing the Kejriwal brand of non-stop agitational politics.

Despite the rising support for his party, I never did believe Kejriwal would form the next government in Delhi. The day before the Delhi assembly election results, I was moderating a session at the *Hindustan Times* Leadership Summit with Pakistan cricket captain-turned-politician, Imran Khan. Before we went on stage, I told Imran that he was a bit like the Arvind Kejriwal of Pakistan. 'How come?' he asked. 'Well, you both have a huge fan base among the young, are very popular on TV and the social media, but you both would probably do better in cyberspace than at the ballot box!' Imran was only faintly amused.

The next day, I was proven wrong. Kejriwal won twenty-eight of the seventy seats in the Delhi assembly while the Congress was decimated with just eight seats and the BJP fell short of a majority with thirty-two seats. Kejriwal held the balance of power. In an interview on 10 December 2013, the day after the results, he told me he would never take Congress support to form a government. A little over a fortnight later, he appeared to conveniently change his mind.

The Congress decision to support Kejriwal was reportedly orchestrated by Rahul Gandhi. Apparently, Rahul was impressed with Kejriwal's style of politics based on youth power and voluntarism. Maybe he liked the idea of an NGO activist transforming himself into an idealistic politician. Or maybe, as some Congressmen suggested to me, he saw Kejriwal as a potential ally in the future battle against a Modi-led BJP.